

1972 Nixon makes a historic visit to communist China and meets Chairman Mao, the first meeting between the leaders of the two countries since the communists took over China in 1949.

1973 Roe v. Wade: a historic Supreme Court decision strikes down state abortion laws as violations of the right to privacy, thus making abortions legal in the US.

1973 Withdrawal of US troops from Vietnam; 58,000 US troops have been killed in the conflict. Two years later, the North Vietnamese take over the south and reunify the country.

1973 Vice president Spiro T. Agnew resigns after a charge of income tax evasion. House minority leader Gerald Ford is appointed vice president.

1974 Richard Nixon resigns following the Watergate scandal over the break-in at Democratic Party headquarters at the Watergate Hotel in Washington, DC, during the 1972 election. Nixon authorized the break-in and then tried to cover up the evidence. The House of Representatives begins impeachment proceedings, but Nixon decides to resign. Gerald Ford succeeds him, becoming the first president never to have been elected as either president or vice president.

1975 Gerald Ford is the object of two assassination attempts in a three-week period in September. He is unharmed in both incidents.

1975 A US Apollo and a Soviet Soyuz spacecraft dock in orbit.

1975 Bill Gates and Paul Allen start Microsoft to develop software for personal computers.

1976 Democrat Jimmy Carter is elected president. Carter, a former governor of Georgia, is the first candidate from the Deep South to be elected president since the Civil War.



1981 IBM PC

IBM's decision to license the PC's technology to other computer-makers led to the proliferation of inexpensive "PC clones," speeding up the adoption of computers in offices and homes.

THE 50 STATES OF THE UNION

NAME	DATE OF ADMISSION	ORDER OF ADMISSION	STATE CAPITAL	AREA (mi ²)	POPULATION (2009 EST)
Alabama (AL)	1819	22	Montgomery	50,744	4,708,708
Alaska (AK)	1959	49	Juneau	571,951	698,473
Arizona (AZ)	1912	48	Phoenix	113,635	6,595,778
Arkansas (AR)	1836	25	Little Rock	52,068	2,889,450
California (CA)	1850	31	Sacramento	155,959	36,961,664
Colorado (CO)	1876	38	Denver	103,717	5,024,748
Connecticut (CT)	1788	5	Hartford	4,844	3,518,388
Delaware (DR)	1787	1	Dover	1,954	885,122
Florida (FL)	1845	27	Tallahassee	53,927	18,537,969
Georgia (GA)	1788	4	Atlanta	57,906	9,829,211
Hawaii (HI)	1959	50	Honolulu	6,423	1,295,178
Idaho (ID)	1890	43	Boise	82,747	1,545,801
Illinois (IL)	1818	21	Springfield	55,584	12,910,409
Indiana (IN)	1816	19	Indianapolis	35,867	6,423,113
Iowa (IA)	1846	29	Des Moines	55,869	3,007,856
Kansas (KS)	1861	34	Topeka	81,815	2,818,747
Kentucky (KY)	1792	15	Frankfort	39,728	4,314,113
Louisiana (LA)	1812	18	Baton Rouge	43,562	4,492,076
Maine (ME)	1820	23	Augusta	30,862	1,318,301
Maryland (MD)	1788	7	Annapolis	9,774	5,600,388
Massachusetts (MA)	1788	6	Boston	7,840	5,699,478
Michigan (MI)	1837	26	Lansing	56,804	9,969,727
Minnesota (MN)	1858	32	St. Paul	79,610	5,266,214
Mississippi (MS)	1817	20	Jackson	46,907	2,951,996
Missouri (MO)	1821	24	Jefferson City	68,886	5,987,580
Montana (MT)	1889	41	Helena	145,552	974,989
Nebraska (NE)	1867	37	Lincoln	76,872	1,796,619
Nevada (NV)	1864	36	Carson City	109,826	2,643,085
New Hampshire (NH)	1788	9	Concord	8,968	1,324,575
New Jersey (NJ)	1787	3	Trenton	7,417	8,717,925
New Mexico (NM)	1912	47	Santa Fe	121,356	2,009,671
New York (NY)	1788	11	Albany	47,214	19,541,453
North Carolina (NC)	1789	12	Raleigh	48,711	9,380,884
North Dakota (ND)	1889	39	Bismarck	68,976	646,844
Ohio (OH)	1803	17	Columbus	40,948	11,542,645
Oklahoma (OK)	1907	46	Oklahoma City	66,667	3,687,050
Oregon (OR)	1859	33	Salem	95,997	3,825,657
Pennsylvania (PA)	1787	2	Harrisburg	117,347	12,604,767
Rhode Island (RI)	1790	13	Providence	1,045	1,053,209
South Carolina (SC)	1788	8	Columbia	30,109	4,561,242
South Dakota (SD)	1889	40	Pierre	75,885	812,383
Tennessee (TN)	1796	16	Nashville	41,217	6,296,254
Texas (TX)	1845	28	Austin	261,797	24,782,302
Utah (UT)	1896	45	Salt Lake City	82,144	2,784,572
Vermont (VT)	1791	14	Montpelier	9,250	621,760
Virginia (VA)	1788	10	Richmond	39,594	7,882,590
Washington (WA)	1889	42	Olympia	66,544	6,664,195
West Virginia (WV)	1863	35	Charleston	24,077	1,819,777
Wisconsin (WI)	1848	30	Madison	54,310	5,654,774
Wyoming (WY)	1890	44	Cheyenne	97,100	544,270
District of Columbia (DC)	—	—	—	69	599,657

1976 US celebrates 200 years of independence.

1977 Apple Computer founders Steve Jobs and Steve Wozniak introduce the Apple II. Easy to use and expandable, it helps create a market for personal computers in homes, offices, and schools.

1977 US agrees to hand back the Canal Zone to Panama in 1999.

1977 A 24-hour blackout strikes New York City on July 13.

1977 A new cabinet department—the Department of Energy—is created.

1978 US-sponsored Camp David accords between Egypt and Israel.

1978 Proposition 13, A statewide referendum that leads to a drastic reduction in property taxes, passes in California and is seen as a sign of a move to the right in American politics.

1979 The Chrysler Corporation asks the federal government for a \$1 billion loan to avoid bankruptcy.

1979 The US Treasury issues the nation's first \$1 coin, bearing the likeness of women's rights pioneer Susan B. Anthony. The coin never wins widespread acceptance.

1979 Nuclear disaster at Three Mile Island power station in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, as a faulty cooling system leads to a meltdown inside the reactor and the release of some radiation: it is the worst nuclear accident in US history.

1979 Iranian militants occupy the US embassy in Tehran and take 52 hostages, who are eventually released after 444 days in captivity.

1980 A botched attempt at rescuing the US hostages in Tehran on April 8 leads to the death of eight servicemen in the Iranian desert.

1980 The US and the People's Republic of China establish diplomatic relations.